



Tap-to-transfer Android 13

Android 13 may have a tap-to-transfer feature for moving media playback between devices. <https://digit.in/feb22-16>



Historic transplant surgery

In a world first, the heart of a genetically modified pig was transplanted into a man. <https://digit.in/feb22-17>

SFX TECHNICIAN

Creating movie magic

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pecial effects and visual effects in films are often terms used interchangeably, but it is wrong to do so.

You, however, cannot fault the uninitiated for doing this since the end results produced by both are visual. However, special effects (SFX) and visual effects (VFX) cater to a different aspect of modern-day cinema. The difference stems from the part they play during the film or TV series' production process. Special effects refer to on-set, real-life techniques that create a certain 'effect' by adding elements into scenes such as smoke, fog, fire, snow, or water. Apart from these, animatronics, robotics and miniature models are also integral parts of SFX. In fact, Yoda from the original Star Wars trilogy was an animatronic. In The Phantom Menace and The Empire Strikes Back films, dwarf actors appeared in costume as Yoda for walking scenes. Frank Oz performed as the lead puppeteer in the Star Wars original trilogy and he puppeteered most of Yoda's scenes. It was only in the Prequel trilogy that Yoda was rendered using CGI, especially

during intense fight scenes. Not only this, SFX also includes prosthetic make-up to provide the desired effect for a character.

Visual effects, on the other hand, is used to digitally create the effects that can be produced via SFX. It refers to any kind of digital enhancement of shots, from adding in backgrounds using greenscreens to creating CGI models and creatures. VFX has essentially taken over a large portion of on-set SFX work, however, the need for SFX technicians is still present to this day, since it is often more authentic, and sometimes, cheaper to produce. Creating high-quality visual effects can get very expensive due to the VFX artists having to work hundreds of hours sometimes for single shots. So, if SFX technicians can replicate the effect on-set, this cost can be lowered. In this article, we will be discussing the career path of an SFX technician, their role, education needed, and skills required.



Yoda in the original Star Wars trilogy was a result of on-set SFX

WHAT IS AN SFX TECHNICIAN REQUIRED TO DO?

As an SFX technician, you would be the one responsible for the on-set visual effects used in the film. A variety of techniques are used to create these non-digital effects including pyrotechnics, claymation, robotics, plastic prosthesis, puppeteering, and others. These non-digital effects are also sometimes termed as 'practical effects'. Usually, SFX technicians specialise in a couple of these techniques. In fact, films with a bigger budget may even allocate one SFX technician for one genre of special effects.

As an SFX technician, you go through various phases as the film or TV series' production progresses. You will need to work as a part of a team, usually under a senior technician or supervisor. It will also be your responsibility to ensure the safety of those on set when working with elements, especially hazardous ones such as fire and smoke. In the pre-production phase, special effects technicians will need to thoroughly study the script and research how to bring certain scenes to life. You may need to make sketches and models of the props you need for the film. Next, you will need to confer with your supervisor or the director of the film to discuss your creative vision. A budget is drawn up to give the director a rough idea of the cost of the effects that would be required. Once the